

*Illustration by* SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

# THIS SHIP HAS SAILED

**Muhammad Yunus** is probably thinking that winning the Nobel Peace prize was far simpler than managing a fractured interim government. While Yunus makes grand declarations about Bangladesh being a haven for people of all faiths, his attorney general calls for the abolition of secularism. The Chief Advisor urges peace, yet it's the army that keeps order on the streets. So here's a question worth pondering: who's really running Bangladesh? Is it Yunus, or the student leaders who orchestrated the July-August uprising that ousted Sheikh Hasina? Is it the military, as has so often been the case in the country's history? The latest twist—just days after the 84-year-old Yunus spoke about revitalising ties with Pakistan, a cargo ship from Karachi docked at Chittagong port, the first since 1971. Not surprisingly, India isn't thrilled about the development.

## Robe Ruckus

Tamil Nadu governor **R.N. Ravi** just can't seem to stay away from controversy, the latest being invitations to a seminar at Raj Bhavan on November 16 which depicted Tamil saint-poet Tiruvalluvar in saffron robes. This sparked a fresh row amid preparations for the silver jubilee celebrations of Tiruvalluvar's statue installation in Kanyakumari, scheduled for the year-end. Traditionally, public images of Tiruvalluvar have always depicted him in white robes, a portrayal that has become culturally iconic. Critics, weary of the ongoing friction between the governor and the ruling DMK, accuse him of deliberately stirring up trouble. Many also argue that instead of creating controversies, Ravi should be packing his bags, questioning why the Centre hasn't recalled him even though his tenure is over.



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Kaushik Deka with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Jumana Shah, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Amarnath K. Menon and Ajay Sukumaran

## COLOUR CLASH



Karnataka minister for housing, Waqf, and minority welfare, **B.Z. Zameer Ahmed Khan**, was already facing flak from the BJP for the 'Waqf adalats' when he got into another bind when he referred to ex-CM H.D. Kumaraswamy of the JD(S) as "Kaalia". The timing couldn't have been worse—it was the eve of the November 13 bypolls in Channapatna. Though he apologised for the remark, which may have been a reference to Kumaraswamy's complexion, Khan's attempts to downplay it as a joke from the days when they were close associates have not been very convincing.

## Pending Priorities



Uncertainty over key appointments in the state BJP is now affecting party affairs in Gujarat. Currently, **C.R. Paatil** is juggling the role of BJP state president along with that of Union Jal Shakti minister while chief spokesperson Yamal Vyas, who was recently made chairman of the Fourth State Finance Commission, continues to hold both positions (his term as spokesman is over). With local body polls approaching, Vyas faces the daunting task of prioritising the financial overhaul of corporations—if he can find the time. Sources say the delay is because the high command is preoccupied with "more pressing matters" concerning Gujarat. Are more surprises in store then?



MANDAR DEODHAR

## PAWAR PUNCH

When it comes to political messaging, NCP (SCP) patriarch **Sharad Pawar** usually prefers the subtle approach. But this Maharashtra assembly election has brought out a combative streak in him, especially against defectors. Speaking at a rally in Ambegaon, the constituency of ex-protege and minister Dilip Walse Patil, Pawar was at his rousing best, urging supporters to "*shambhar takke parabhut, kara, kara, kara* (Defeat him 100 per cent, do it, do it, do it)". Over to the voters now.